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In immigration battle, Vt. stands tall

2 federal judges in liberal district push back hard

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

All roads have led to Louisiana as the Trump administration has sought to detain and deport international students and scholars who have spoken out against Israel.

In at least five high-profile cases in recent months, federal agents have attempted to ship such detainees from the Northeast to jails in Louisiana. The government's goal,

defense lawyers have alleged, has been to "forum shop" — or ensure that their cases are heard in one of the most conservative federal districts in the country.

But at least two of those detainees — Tufts University graduate student Rümeysa Öztürk and Columbia University student Mohsen Mahdawi — have instead wound up in the legal clutches of one of the nation's most liberal districts: Vermont. That's led to a series of sympathetic rulings, including one Wednesday that saw Mahdawi, a legal permanent resident who grew up in the Palestinian territories, walking out of a Burlington court-

house on bail.

Vermont's outsize role in the international fracas might seem surprising, given its tiny population and its small share of the nation's immigrants. The state's turn in the spotlight appears to be a combination of happenstance, quick work by the pair's lawyers, and — at least in Mahdawi's case — bungling by federal agents.

According to court filings, the agents who detained Mahdawi at a citizenship interview in Vermont last month rushed him to a nearby airport to whisk him to Louisiana, but missed their flight. That gave a federal judge in Vermont, William

K. Sessions III, enough time to issue an order keeping him in the state.

"It would be farcical if it weren't so despicable," said Lia Ernst, legal director of the ACLU of Vermont, who has helped represent both students. "They're playing these games with people's lives and people's safety and people's freedom."

Marilyn Skoglund, a retired Vermont Supreme Court justice, called the forum-shopping flop "a big boo-boo."

"Anybody who gets stuck in Vermont is in good shape," she said.

That, according to Skoglund and other legal experts, owes largely to

VERMONT, Page A7

Trump's budget calls for huge cuts

Biggest targets: science, health, and education

By Tony Romm
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Friday proposed slashing \$163 billion in federal spending next fiscal year, a drastic retrenchment in the role and reach of government that, if enacted, would eliminate a vast set of climate, education, health, and housing programs, including some that benefit the poor.

Issuing his first budget proposal since returning to office, Trump sketched out a dim view of Washington. His blueprint depicted many core government functions as woke, weaponized, wasteful, or radical, as the president looked to justify his request that Congress chop domestic spending to its lowest level in the modern era.

Trump proposed cutting funding for some federal law enforcement, including the FBI. He called on lawmakers to slash money meant to police tax evasion at the IRS. He recommended striking billions in funds that help finance clean water projects. And the president reserved some of his deepest cuts for education, health, and science, including the National Institutes of Health and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, which

BUDGET, Page A7



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Third-graders at the Elizabeth Carter Brooks Elementary School in New Bedford got down to work.

LEARNING THE HARD WAY

COVID's disruption has left many students far behind where they were in 2020

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

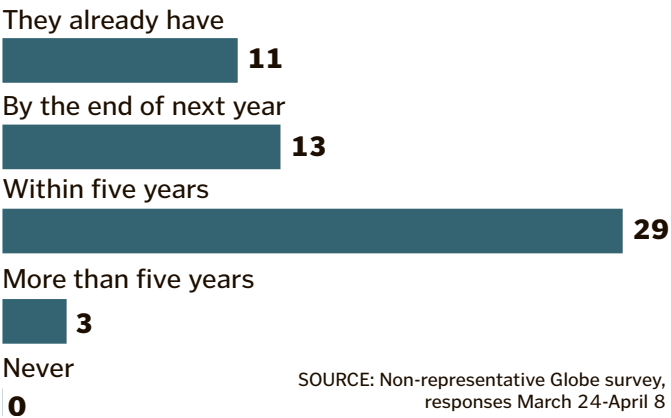
It's a generation permanently scarred.

Five years after the COVID-19 pandemic began, Massachusetts students remain far behind where they were when the global health catastrophe struck and school leaders undertook the drastic step of shutting in-person learning down for months.

This is despite billions of dollars in federal aid to redress the damage done by prolonged school closures. Math skills have stagnated and reading achievement has worsened. Children who were not yet in high school when schools closed their doors

Catching up from pandemic losses

Massachusetts superintendent responses to: When do you expect student test scores in your district to return to pre-pandemic levels?



have graduated less equipped to navigate the world than those who came before.

Dozens of Massachusetts superintendents surveyed by the Globe said it will be years before students catch up. While a minority said their students have already matched pre-pandemic scores or will by the end of next year — six years after schools closed — most said it will take longer.

Even in 2019, students here and across the country were learning less, and the advantages Massachusetts once had in teaching all student groups — rich and poor, white and Black, native

Mass. Pike Allston project may lose key federal funds

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

For months, community advocates have warned that the state risked losing its last critical source of funding, some \$335 million promised by the federal government, for the massive project to rebuild the Massachusetts Turnpike through Allston that would also open a huge amount of land for new development.

Those warnings now sound prescient after Republican leaders of a key House committee proposed permanently rescinding more than \$3 billion in funds awarded to projects that would reconnect communities divided by interstate highways and other large transportation projects.

The massive \$2 billion Allston Multimodal Project, as the turnpike project is known, would free up space along the Charles River for new development, including a new transit hub, and for new bike and pedestrian connections. It was among several projects in Massachusetts that

ALLSTON, Page A10



Hello mudder

Paramilitary forces killed more than 100 civilians in an attack on a city in southern Sudan, according to an association of doctors. **A4.**

The SJC ruled that responding to an online prostitution ad does not count as human trafficking, heading off an aggressive line of prosecution aimed at "johns." **B1.**

Edaville Family Theme Park in Carver sold off virtually all of its attractions as it made way for King Richard's Faire. **D1.**

Jennifer McCabe took the witness stand for a third day in Karen Read's murder trial in Norfolk Superior Court and continued to spar with defense attorney Alan Jackson. **B2.**

More US children have died this flu season than at any time since 2010. **A6.**

The Celtics have some time to prepare for their next opponent, the New York Knicks, with Game 1 on Monday. **C1.**

Making Harvard pay — but not like that

Many in Cambridge agree with Trump on one thing — school has more to give

By Spencer Buell and Catherine Carlock
GLOBE STAFF

CAMBRIDGE — The flier featured a picture of Mr. Monopoly, holding a crimson-red bag of cash, dashing toward a map of Harvard Square.

It beckoned people to a community meeting in a high school library, and posed

►Trump's tax threat sparks outcry. **B1.**

the question residents here have been asking for many years: "What does Harvard owe?"

That was in long-ago March, when the people calling for Harvard University to pay more in taxes were unions, elected officials, and neighborhood associations.

Now, someone else is joining that chorus: Donald Trump, who last month suggested the IRS should consider revoking Harvard's tax-exempt status entirely. Friday morning on social media, Trump



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

If Harvard paid property tax like a for-profit business, its taxes would be substantial.

made a more forceful pledge: "We are going to be taking away Harvard's Tax Exempt Status," he posted on his social media site. "It's what they deserve!"

It's been a common refrain across Cambridge for decades that Harvard — which does not have to pay property tax on its bil-

HARVARD, Page A10

Saturday: Warm, storms. High 78-83. Low 55-60.
Sunday: Cloudy, cooler. High 62-67. Low 48-53.
High tide: 4:09 a.m., 5:01 p.m.
Sunrise: 5:36 Sunset: 7:46
Weather and Comics, D4-5. Obituaries, C9.

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